CURATING HISTORY

1.2 Voorhees Archaearium Jamestown, Virginia

Located near the site of the original Jamestown Settlement, America's first permanent English colony, the Voorhees Archaearium captures the story of Virginia in the 1600s. Artifacts from the arrival of English colonists to Jamestown in 1607 and the earliest cultural encounters and events are housed in this archaeology museum. Visitors can explore the cultures of the Native Americans, Europeans, and Africans who intersected in 17th-century Virginia, and trace Jamestown's beginnings in England. They can even climb aboard replicas of the three ships, moored nearby, that crossed the Atlantic, bringing the earliest colonists from England to Virginia. What can you infer about the lives of the colonists based on the artifacts below?



Lead Toy Horse

A collection of tiny toy horses like this one was found in a trash heap along with food remains, broken pottery, and shattered glassware from the James Fort. Long ago, this horse may have carried a toy rider in its saddle and had wheels so a child could push or pull it around.



Gaming Dice

Excavations have revealed more than 60 gaming dice at the James Fort. Many of the dice are made of animal bone, but some are made of ivory or lead. It's possible that the lead dice may have been made by a soldier who also made lead shot (fired by weapons) at the fort. Like modern dice, the opposing sides of the Jamestown dice add up to seven. Soldiers passed the long hours at the remote fort playing dice games.

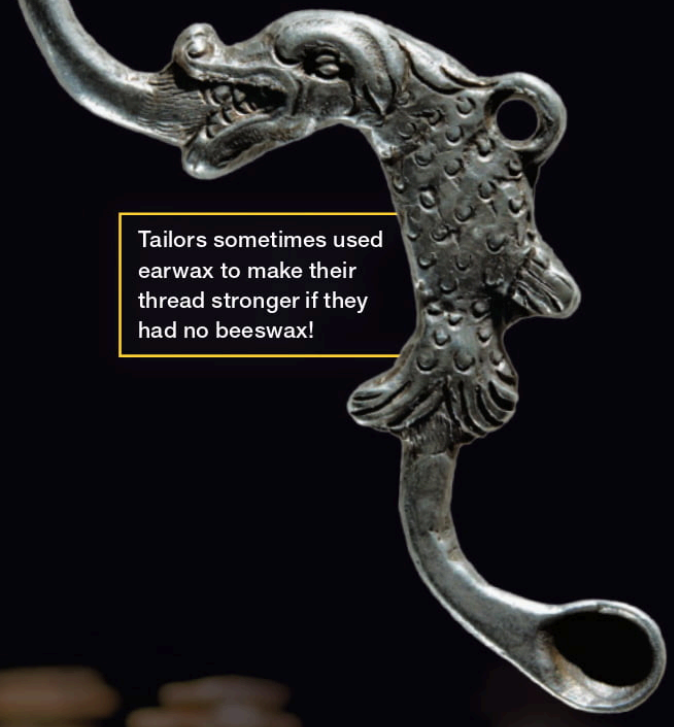


Brass Thimble

This 16th-century thimble was made in Nuremberg, Germany, and is one of 11 brass thimbles found at the James Fort. Several tailors joined the Jamestown colonists in 1607 and 1608, and their ability to sew and repair cloth was important to the frontier settlement. Other tailoring tools have also been found, including needles, irons, and pins.

Ear Picker

Believe it or not, a Jamestown colonist once used this silver sea creature to scrape teeth, clean dirt from fingernails, and scoop out earwax. Gold and silver grooming tools were often worn like jewelry in Europe during the late 1500s and early 1600s. The first settlers at Jamestown included a surgeon and a barber who could perform basic medical care like removing infected teeth—and excessive earwax.



Tailors sometimes used earwax to make their thread stronger if they had no beeswax!

Why might the English have felt it was safer to drink wine than water in the early 1600s?

Monogrammed Wine Bottles

Discovered by Jamestown archaeologists, these wide glass bottles were made in England between 1680 and 1700 and found upright on the dirt floor of a rectangular cellar. One of the intact bottles is marked with the initials *FN,* which reveals it once belonged to someone of wealth and status. During the 17th century, high-ranking gentlemen liked to order wine bottles from England stamped with their personal seal.